PLAYBOOK . COPILOT

A first *safe week* for people who use Copilot at work

Copilot is often the easy switch for companies that already run on Microsoft. People say Copilot and mean different products, so the first job is to find out which one you have.

If you are not sure where to start

People often do not call it fear. Said out loud, it sounds like one of these:

- "**What if I break something?**" The first week asks you to send nothing, delete nothing, and put nothing sensitive in.
- "**I do not know what to do.**" Each day has one small job, and the first one is reading a document.
- "**I do not know where to start.**" Start with the rules at your company. That is Monday.
- "**I do not know what it could do for me.**" The section on where people find real time shows the places worth trying.
- "**What if I cannot do what I am supposed to do with it?**" You do not need to be technical. You need to check the work, and the kit gives you a way to do that.
- "**Am I even allowed?**" That is the policy check, and it comes first.

Each of these is a fair thing to wonder, and each one gets a next step below.

This guide works with any tool. Copilot is often the easy one to switch on, since many large companies already run on Microsoft, but it is not the only one. The playbooks for ChatGPT, Gemini, and Claude cover the others.

> **Before anything else: check your employer's policy**
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> Your company decides what you may put into an AI tool, and which tools you may use. Find the written policy (often called an acceptable use, AI use, or information security policy). If you cannot find one, ask your manager or your IT or security team, and keep the answer in writing. Everything in this guide sits under that policy. If the two ever disagree, the policy wins.

Which Copilot do you actually have?

For a lot of people, Copilot is the easy first tool. Many large companies already run on Microsoft and can switch Copilot on without buying anything new, and plenty of employees then barely use it. It is not the only tool, and some companies roll out ChatGPT, Gemini, or Claude instead. Whatever you were given, the rest of this kit applies. This page helps you tell the Copilot versions apart.

Microsoft is renaming these products. Its own page says "Microsoft 365 Copilot is now named Microsoft Copilot, and Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat is now named Microsoft Copilot Chat," and that some screens still use the older names. Trust the label on your screen.

Copilot (free)	Microsoft describes it as available at no cost at copilot.cloud.microsoft. Signing in is not required, and signing in with a personal account adds chat history and other features. It is a personal service, so keep work content out of it unless your employer says you may.
Copilot Chat (work account)	Included with eligible Microsoft 365 business licenses. Microsoft says it is grounded on the web, not on your organization's files, emails, or chats by default. A green shield next to New Chat means enterprise data protection applies. Microsoft states that prompts and responses are not used to train its foundation models.
Microsoft Copilot (add-on license)	An add-on license that, per Microsoft, includes everything in Copilot Chat plus chat that can respond using your work data such as files, emails, and chats. Not everyone at a company has it.

How to tell which you have

Microsoft's page "What Copilot license do I have" says that with a work or school account, one of three labels appears under your name: **Copilot Chat** (**Basic**), **M365 Copilot** (**Basic**), or **M365 Copilot** (**Premium**). Per Microsoft, Premium means you have the add-on license, and Basic means you do not. Open Copilot, sign in with your work account, and look for the label. If you do not see one, ask your IT team.

What this means for your first week

- **Signed in with your work account and seeing the green shield?** You are in the protected work version, which is where work content belongs, if your policy allows it.
- **Prompts are logged.** Microsoft says prompts and responses in Copilot Chat are logged, and that your IT admin can use Microsoft's search and audit tools to view them. Write every prompt as if a colleague in IT could read it later.

- **Work content can still get in.** Per Microsoft, you can add it by pasting, by uploading a file with the plus button, by picking a file from the slash menu, or by using Copilot Chat in Outlook or an agent that has access to organizational content. Know which of these you are doing.
- **Open files.** Microsoft says that when you use the Word, Excel, or PowerPoint agents, Copilot Chat is aware of the file you have open and cannot access other work data unless you provide it.

Sources, read on 2026-10-17. Microsoft Learn, "Microsoft Copilot Chat Privacy and Protections" (shows last updated 08/24/2026): learn.microsoft.com/en-us/copilot/privacy-and-protections. Microsoft Support, "Data protection when using Microsoft Copilot Chat for work or school": support.microsoft.com/en-us/privacy/data-protection-when-using-microsoft-365-copilot-chat-for-work-or-school. Microsoft Support, "What Copilot license do I have" (last updated April 2026): support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/what-copilot-license-do-i-have. Microsoft Support, "What's the difference between Microsoft Copilot (free) and Copilot in Microsoft 365". Product names and plans change, so check your own screen.

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The risk ladder

Not every use of AI carries the same risk. Start at the bottom of the ladder and move up only when you have a reason and the policy allows it.

Step 1 No company information goes in	Explain a concept you are new to. Brainstorm names, agendas, or questions for a meeting. Practice a hard conversation using made-up details. Ask how a spreadsheet formula works, using made-up rows. Draft a blank template you will fill in yourself. Turn your own rough notes about a public topic into an outline.
Step 2 Work content goes in, with care	Summarize your own meeting notes. Turn your bullets into a draft email. Tidy a list. Ask for the formula that fits your column names. Plan a dashboard or report. Only after the policy says yes, only the minimum content, names and numbers removed or replaced, and everything checked by you before it goes anywhere.
Step 3 Do not use AI for this	Personal data about employees, customers, patients, or candidates. Anything confidential, privileged, or not yet public. Passwords and keys. Anything your policy forbids. Decisions about a person's job, pay, or performance. Anything you have no way to check. Sending to a customer or a regulator without you reading every line.

Set your context once

A short plain-text note about your work saves you from retyping the same background in every chat, and keeps answers closer to what you need. Keep it as a file you own. Paste it at the start of a new chat, or into the custom instructions of the tool your company provides. Tools change; the file stays yours.

Never put anything in it that your policy would not let you type into the tool. Roles and reader types are fine. Names, numbers, and client details are not.

Where it goes: In Copilot, paste the note at the start of a new chat. If your version has a personalization or custom instructions setting, you can keep it there, but check the setting on your own screen first.

```
My role: [your job title, in a few words]
Who reads my work: [for example: my manager, the finance team, customers]
How I write: [short sentences, plain words, no jargon]
Words I use: [terms people in my team use]
What stays out: [anything I never put in a chat]
How to answer: ask me one question if something is unclear, say what you are
unsure of, and show your steps when you do math.
```

The verification habit

AI can be fluent and wrong in the same sentence. A spreadsheet with a broken formula opens exactly like a correct one, so you build the check yourself. Before anything leaves your hands:

1. **Numbers by hand.** Pick three rows and work them out yourself. If your math and the formula agree, keep it. If not, you caught it.
2. **Names, dates, and quotes against the original.** Open the source and compare. Do not ask the AI to confirm itself.
3. **Ask what it is unsure of.** "What in this answer might be wrong, and how would I check it?" is a fair question.
4. **Read it as the person who receives it.** Would they act on it? Would they trust it?
5. **When a draft fails twice, stop editing it.** Open a new chat with a bare brief: who reads it, what they should do, three things it must not do.

Your first safe week

Each day is a small step. The week asks you to send nothing, delete nothing, and put nothing sensitive in. Fifteen to twenty minutes a day is plenty.

Monday	**Read the rules.** Find your employer's policy. Note which tool your company provides and sign in with your work account, not a personal one. Write down anything you are unsure about and ask.
Tuesday	**Step 1 only.** Use the tool for something with no company information in it: explain a concept, plan a meeting agenda with made-up details, ask how a formula works. Get a feel for how it answers.
Wednesday	**Set your context.** Fill in the context note above and paste it into a new chat. Ask for help with a task and notice how the answer changes.
Thursday	**One Step 2 task, if the policy allows.** Pick something small from your own work. Take out names and numbers first. Run the verification habit on the result before you use any of it.
Friday	**Look back.** Three lines in your notes: what saved time, what needed fixing, what you will not use it for. Then fill in the first rows of the AI audit worksheet.

Beyond email: where people find the real time

Email is where most people start and stop. These are the places that tend to repay the effort, each with the same rule: you check the result.

- **Spreadsheet formulas.** Paste the column names, never the data. Add a few made-up rows with the same shape. Ask for the formula and a plain explanation of each piece. Check three rows by hand.
- **Report and dashboard planning.** Write down the decisions the report must support, then ask for the smallest set of views that serve them. Every tile should name the decision it serves.
- **Meeting preparation.** Questions to ask, objections to expect, and the one risk to raise, from your own agenda.
- **Plain-language rewrites.** Turn a dense policy or procedure you own into something a new hire can follow.
- **Practice conversations.** Rehearse a hard conversation against a made-up person before the real one.
- **Checklists and templates.** Draft the blank version of anything you do repeatedly, then fill it in yourself.
- **Reading long documents.** Ask for the decision a document is asking you to make, then go and read the parts that matter.

- **Finding what you have never defined.** Before asking AI to analyze your data, ask it what terms in your question need a definition.

Where AI should not be used

- **Anything your policy does not allow.** This beats every other rule in this guide.
- **Personal data about people.** Employees, customers, patients, candidates, students.
- **Anything confidential or not yet public.** Financial results, legal matters, contracts, plans, source code, client material.
- **Decisions about a person.** Hiring, firing, pay, ratings, discipline. A tool can help you prepare. The decision and the reasons are yours.
- **Passwords, keys, and access details.**
- **Anything you cannot check.** If you cannot tell whether the answer is right, it is not ready to use.
- **Work sent to someone else unread.** You are the author of whatever leaves under your name.

> **You do not have to know everything first.** Worrying you will break something, not knowing what to do or where to start, not knowing what AI could do for your work, or doubting that you can do what you are supposed to do with it: these are normal places to begin, and they are good instincts, not weaknesses. This guide gives each one a next step: a policy check first, a ladder you climb slowly, and a habit that catches errors before anyone else does. Starting small and checking as you go is a perfectly good way to learn this.
>
> General information for working people. Not legal, compliance, or HR advice. Your employer's policy and your own judgment decide what is right for you.

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